



PRESIDENT TRUMP, with granddaughter Kai, spoke about the indictment of James Comey with reporters.

No ‘smoking gun’: Why Eaton fire report didn’t assign blame

By GRACE TOOHEY, JENNY JARVIE AND REBECCA ELLIS

The long-awaited Los Angeles County report examining the botched evacuation alerts in Altadena during the deadly Eaton fire cited a long list of shortcomings, from preparation to tactics.

But the after-action report into the fire that killed 19 people — all but one of them in west Altadena —

stopped short of singling out individual leaders for those issues, and it failed to provide a detailed explanation for why evacuation orders in west Altadena came hours after smoke and flames started to threaten the area.

While the report, by Virginia-based consulting firm McChrystal Group, confirmed The Times’ reporting that first revealed the late evacuation orders, it did not detail exactly who or what was responsible for the breakdown, which county of-

ficials have previously called “an epic fail.”

That lack of blame appears to have arisen by design, despite fire victims’ repeated calls for accountability.

“This report does not investigate wrongdoing or assign blame,” the authors state at the beginning of the 132-page report, commissioned by the L.A. County Board of Supervisors at a cost of \$2 million and released Thursday. “Its purpose is to assess the Coun-

ty’s alert and evacuation systems ... and provide actionable recommendations to strengthen future response efforts.”

L.A. County Supervisor Kathryn Barger, who represents Altadena, called for the review after The Times reported in January that almost all the Eaton fire deaths occurred on the unincorporated town’s west side. In her motion, Barger cited “questions that have arisen” about the evacua-

Legal experts say indictment is test of justice

Trump’s targeting of Comey and other perceived foes upends the system, some say.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — On a Phoenix tarmac in 2016, former President Clinton and U.S. Atty. Gen. Loretta Lynch had a serendipitous meeting on a private jet. The exchange caused a political firestorm. At a time when the Justice Department was investigating Hillary Clinton, the Democratic nominee for president, the appearance of impropriety prompted a national scandal.

“Lynch made law enforcement decisions for political purposes,” Donald Trump, her Republican rival that year, would later write of the meeting on Twitter. “Totally illegal!”

It was the beginning of a pattern from Trump claiming political interference by Democrats and career public servants in Justice Department matters, regardless of the evidence.

Now, Trump’s years-long claim that it was his opponents who politicized the justice system has become the basis for the most aggressive spree of political prosecutions in modern American history.

“What Trump is doing now with the U.S. attorneys is really in complete opposition to how the people who created those offices imagined what those officials would do — the Founders simply did not envision the office in this way,” said Peter Kastor, chair of the history department at Washington University in St. Louis.

“From the inception of the Justice Department,” he added, “one of the most remarkable things is how it was never used in this way.”

On Thursday, at Trump’s express direction, federal charges were filed against James Comey, the former FBI director, alleging he gave false testimony before Congress and attempted to obstruct a congressional proceeding five years ago.

The indictment was secured from a federal grand jury after Trump fired a U.S. attorney with doubts about

[See Justice, A6]

Feds sue California over its voter rolls

Justice Department argues officials of this state and others must hand over the records.

By KEVIN RECTOR

The U.S. Justice Department sued California Secretary of State Shirley Weber on Thursday for failing to hand over the state’s voter rolls, alleging she is unlawfully preventing federal authorities from ensuring state compliance with federal voting regulations and safeguarding federal elections against fraud.

The Justice Department also sued Weber’s counterparts in Michigan, Minnesota, New York, New Hampshire and Pennsylvania, who have similarly declined its requests for their states’ voter rolls.

“Clean voter rolls are the foundation of free and fair elections,” Atty. Gen. Pam Bondi said in a statement on the litigation. “Every state has a responsibility to ensure that voter registration

records are accurate, accessible, and secure — states that don’t fulfill that obligation will see this Department of Justice in court.”

In its lawsuit against Weber, who is the state’s top elections official, the Justice Department argues that it is charged — including under the National Voter Registration Act — with ensuring that states have proper protocols for registering voters and maintaining accurate and up-to-date rolls, and therefore is due access to state voter rolls to ensure they are so maintained.

“The United States has now been forced to bring the instant action to seek legal remedy for Defendants’ refusal to comply with lawful requests pursuant to federal law,” the lawsuit states.

Weber, in a statement, called the lawsuit “a fishing expedition and pretext for partisan policy objectives,” a “blatant overreach” and “an unprecedented intrusion unsupported by law or any previous practice or policy of the U.S. Department of Justice.”

[See Voter rolls, A7]

New tariff could hike the price of drugs

A 100% tax is planned to be imposed on some pharmaceuticals starting Wednesday.

By LAUREN DEZENSKI, MADISON MULLER AND JENNIFER A. DLOUHY

President Trump announced a fresh round of tariffs on pharmaceuticals, heavy trucks and furniture, including a 100% duty on patented drugs unless the producer is building a manufacturing plant in the U.S.

“Starting October 1st, 2025, we will be imposing a 100% Tariff on any branded or patented Pharmaceutical Product, unless a Company IS BUILDING their Pharmaceutical Manufacturing Plant in America,” Trump posted on social media Thursday, without offering specifics on which producers will be affected. “There will, therefore, be no Tariff on these Pharmaceutical Products if construction has started.”

Trump’s post was one of several on new industry-focused tariffs set to begin Wednesday. Imported heavy trucks will be subject to a 25% duty, kitchen cabinets and bathroom vanities will be hit with a 50% charge, and upholstered furniture imports are to be taxed at 30%.

Taken together, the moves amount to a rapid expansion of Trump’s tariff regime, which he started to erect shortly after taking office. It comes at a time when the president has flexed his executive powers like none of his modern predecessors. Just as Trump made the levies public, former FBI Director James Comey — a long-time Trump political enemy — was indicted on perjury charges under heavy pressure from the president.

Most European drug-makers slumped in early

[See Tariff, A12]

In age of AI cheating, how do teachers draw the line?

By Howard Blume and Jocelyn Gecker

A teacher tells a student not to use AI in a research assignment. But when the student does a browser search, an AI-generated explanation pops up unprompted.

Has the student just cheated? What now?

Navigating the use and misuse of artificial intelligence in school is complex and confusing — especially when it comes to cheating.

“The cheating is off the charts. It’s the

worst I’ve seen in my entire career,” said Valencia High School English teacher Casey Cuny, a 23-year veteran. “Anything you send home, you have to assume is being AI’ed,” he said.

In late 2022, after ChatGPT launched, many schools initially banned AI, fearing it would be used to churn out term papers, compose presentations and farm out math homework. And even though such uses have come to pass, views on

[See Cheating, A9]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

THE TREE-LINED North Hillcrest Road has proved to be a popular photo spot.

Visitors impose to pose with palms

Beverly Hills streets have seen tourists standing in the road for the perfect shot despite safety concerns

By Christopher Buchanan

The man stood in the middle of the road in decadent Beverly Hills, gawking at one of those only-in-L.A. streetscapes.

He was looking at a row of palm trees in linear formation, like soldiers awaiting inspection, lining the road as far as the eye could see. Alongside the Spanish colonial homes, the scene is a picturesque look into wealth, opulence and super-

fluity that only a select few Angelenos can afford.

For minutes, the man remained in the street, attempting to snap a selfie and document the view. Then suddenly, a blaring car horn yanked him back to reality — without having known, or cared, he stood directly behind a reversing car, in front of a fully occupied home.

Near-accidents like these are a daily occurrence on

this stretch of North Hillcrest Road, where the perfect row of Canary Island date palm trees have made it the TikTok and Instagram geolocation of choice for locals, film crews and tourists.

“We just saw it on TikTok and wanted to take some fun pictures,” said Brandon Lopez, who was visiting from Peru and shooting photos of his girlfriend on film. “It’s a

[See Palm tree, A9]

Sinclair, Nexstar return ‘Kimmel’

Two station owners say they will air late-night show after ABC parent Disney faced a wave of criticism. **BUSINESS, A10**

Trump threatens World Cup cities

His musing about moving games from some Democratic-run areas is unlikely to be realized. **SPORTS, B8**



ALEXI J. ROSENFELD Getty Images

‘FINISH THE JOB’

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu tells the U.N. that the war against Hamas will not end until Israel’s goals are reached. **WORLD, A3**

Weather
A stray thundershower.
L.A. Basin: 77/65. **B8**

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